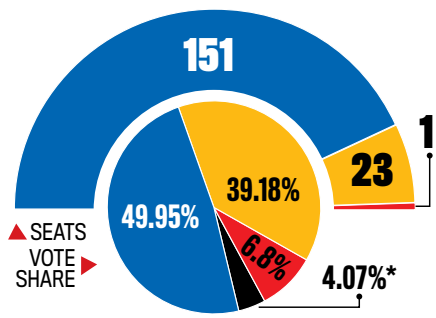
If you can't beat him, join others who can. At least that seems to be the strategy of the Bharatiya Janata Party, Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP) and actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP) as they plan to take on the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) and its founder, Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, for the simultaneous assembly and parliamentary polls next year. Reddy himself firmly believes that his party, which won 151 of the 175 assembly seats and 22 of the 25 Lok Sabha seats in 2019, can only do better. His belief stems from the slew of welfare schemes and populist measures that his government has launched in the past four years, which cover nearly all sections of society. The state government claims that 29 of its direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes involving an expenditure of Rs 2.26 lakh crore have reached nearly 81.7 million beneficiaries in four years; another 11 non-DBT schemes with an expense of Rs 2.32 lakh crore have touched 53.8 million lives in the state.



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Total seats: **175**



*Includes NOTA

TDP supremo Chandrababu Naidu, who has served as chief minister longer than anyone else in the Telugu states, knows that dislodging the YSRCP is not an easy task. In 2019, the latter polled 49.95 per cent of the votes while the dethroned TDP secured 39.18 per cent of the votes and a mere 23 seats. Thus Naidu's keenness to have the JSP and the BJP on his side. The three had fought the 2014 assembly election together, in which the TDP had coasted to a comfortable victory. But Naidu snapped ties with the BJP-led NDA (National Democratic Alliance) before the 2019 election and joined hands with the Congress, only to suffer a humiliating defeat. The JSP, too, had drifted away from the BJP in 2019 to contest in alliance with the CPI (Communist Party of India), CPI-M (Marxist) and the BSP (Bahujan Samaj Party). It bagged 6.8 per cent of the votes in a disastrous electoral debut that saw it win just a single seat. Kalyan lost from both the constituencies he contested from. The party's allies got less than 1 per cent votes.

Having discovered that trouncing the YSRCP alone was a well nigh impossible feat, the JSP forged links with the BJP afresh in 2020. Kalyan also pushed for the TDP to be inducted into the alliance, like in 2014, to achieve their common goal. But the BJP is currently keeping the TDP at bay, even after Naidu called on Union home minister Amit Shah on June 3—their first meeting in five years—hoping to rebuild bridges with the saffron formation.

The BJP is not opposed to the idea of the three coming together again per se. It is certainly seeking leverage, having polled 0.84 per cent of the votes and drawn a blank in terms of seats, when it contested alone in 2019. The vote share was 1.28 per cent for those who exercised the NOTA (none of the above) option. Earlier this month, the party inducted Daggubati Purandeswari, Naidu's sister-in-law and the third daughter of TDP founder N.T. Rama Rao, as state BJP chief, hoping to ensure a smoother coalescing of the alliance while targeting the YSRCP.

However, the TDP, as a cadre-based party with support across the state, remains the dominant player. Kalyan's campaign has helped widen support for the JSP, especially in the Godavari Delta region. The BJP has no choice but to rely on them unless it attempts to boost the party's position by announcing a special category status for Andhra Pradesh or extending a massive grant to compensate for the loss of Hyderabad as the capital to Telangana.

Naidu's game plan—in addition to contesting as an alliance—is to make the most of the anti-incumbency factor. In the pursuit of that objective, he has dispatched his son and TDP national general secretary, Nara Lokesh, on a 'Yuva Galam' (Voice of Youth) yatra (see *Walking the Talk*), like Naidu Sr himself had before the 2014 election. Lokesh has covered more than half the 4,000 km trek, beginning on January 27, from Kuppam, Naidu's constituency, and passed through the Rayalaseema region, including the YSRCP bastion and Reddy's Kadapa district. The padayatra is currently moving up the Andhra coast and on the 157th day, July 17, it was at Malepadu near Ongole.

The TDP is also sceptical of the electoral capi-